

EZEQUIEL MOLINA

Senior Economist | Digital Innovation & AI Leader | Education Global Practice

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PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

Winner of the inaugural WBG Presidential Innovation Award (2025) for "From Learning to Earning: Leveraging AI to Develop Skills for Jobs," personally leading the pitch to President Ajay Banga (1 of 7 winners selected Bank-wide). Recognized as one of the World Bank's leading voices on artificial intelligence in development, with AI and digital publications achieving over 185,000 downloads in about two years—comparable to flagship WDR reach with minimal publicity—and AI Tuesday newsletter reaching 10,000+ Bank staff weekly across all regions.

Pioneer in creating and scaling global public goods for digital transformation. Developed flagship programs now operating across multiple countries: Teach (40+ countries, 180,000+ teachers), Coach (15+ countries), and El Director LIBRE (AI training program scaling across LAC with 2,000+ school directors trained in Peru, 27,000+ downloads since November 2025 launch). These programs demonstrate ability to design, validate, and scale digital solutions from concept to multi-country implementation.

Deep expertise in technology-enabled service delivery transformation across diverse development contexts, from fragile states (Afghanistan, Laos, Mozambique) to sophisticated middle-income economies (Chile, Uruguay, Brazil). Proven track record of ministerial-level policy dialogue, complex multi-stakeholder program management, and private sector partnerships with Google, Microsoft, and Anthropic.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Economist, Education Global Practice | LAC Region (Aug 2023 - Present)

Regional Focal Point for Teachers and Educational Technology | Task Team Leader for Chile and Peru

- **Digital Innovation Leadership:** Winner of inaugural WBG Presidential Innovation Award; AI Champion for Education GP; created AI Tuesday newsletter reaching 10,000+ Bank staff; delivered AI training to 200+ colleagues across 5 regions; positioned Bank as regional thought leader on AI in education.
- **AI Programs Scaling Across LAC:** Leading multi-country AI training initiative with standardized products (El Director LIBRE, El Docente LIBRE) adapted to local contexts. Peru: RCT with 1,270 teachers (~500 treated) showing sustained adoption; 2,000 school directors trained nationally. El Salvador: RCT on El Director LIBRE with DLI integration into World Bank operation.
- **Partnership Development:** Led Education Digitalization MoU with Inter-American Development Bank coordinating regional AI strategy across multilateral institutions. Established public-private partnership with Fundación Romero (Peru's largest bank's foundation), Microsoft, and UPC university to scale AI training nationally.
- **Task Team Leader for Chile:** Led Reimbursable Advisory Services on ECE financing equity, advising Minister of Education and Budget Office (DIPRES) on fiscal sustainability. Designed new ECE financing scheme through comparative analysis of 6+ countries and provider cost analysis.
- **Task Team Leader for Peru:** Co-TTL for Science, Technology & Innovation Project (\$82.5M) coordinating cross-GP teams (Education and FCI). Rebuilt policy dialogue with Ministry following ministerial transition, transforming initial resistance into flagship AI initiative featured by Microsoft CEO.
- **Regional Advisory Support:** Advisor to El Salvador's \$500M transformational EdTech and AI education reform, contributing to the DLI architecture of the country's largest education operation. Preparing regional MPA for 'LearnAI for Jobs' with four pillars: AI training, personalized learning apps, connectivity/devices, and AI solutions for operational efficiency.

Senior Economist, Global Knowledge and Innovation Unit (GEAK) (Sep 2020 - Aug 2023)

Global Lead, Teachers Thematic Group | TTL for Teach and Coach Global Programs

- **Global Public Goods Scaling:** Created Teach, a classroom observation tool now adopted by 40+ countries, UNESCO, UNICEF, and multiple NGOs, reaching 180,000+ teachers and 3.6M students. Secured \$10M+ in trust fund financing through investment case development, resource mobilization, and donor engagement. Built and mentored global team of 15+ staff and consultants across 4 regions.
- **Task Team Leader for Lao PDR GPE III (\$47M):** Led education financing reforms through results-based mechanisms with 5 DLIs. Designed and implemented national primary education block grant allocation formula for 4,500+ schools in 148 districts. Turned around challenging project from 4% to 25% disbursement in one year through intensive client dialogue.
- **Flagship Knowledge Products:** Principal author of Making Teacher Policy Work (2023), World Bank flagship publication on teacher compensation systems and financing sustainability with behavioral insights framework now applied across Education GP operations.

Economist, Global Knowledge and Innovation Unit (GEAK) (Sep 2017 - Sep 2020)

- **Teach Development and Launch:** Led development of Teach classroom observation tool from concept through validation to global deployment. Published Teach validation study.
- **Coach Conceptualization:** Conceived Coach program, raised \$7M funding, built and managed multi-country implementation team.
- **Multi-country Operations:** Team member for Afghanistan, Argentina, Brazil, Mozambique, and Uruguay operations. Designed DLIs and verification protocols, contributed to PADs and concept notes.

Young Professional, World Bank (2015 - 2017)

- **WDR 2017 Core Team:** Authored Chapter 2 on political economy of policy failure in education and health for World Development Report on Governance and the Law.
- **Service Delivery Indicators:** Led SDI survey design in Afghanistan and Tanzania. Developed SABER Service Delivery and Teachers tools.

Earlier World Bank Experience (2006 - 2015)

Economist, Africa HD (2014-2015) | Extended Consultant, Gender Innovation Lab (2013) | Short-Term Consultant (2011-2012) | Junior Professional Associate, LCR Poverty (2007-2009). Led Service Delivery Indicators survey in Mozambique. Contributed to Human Opportunity Index research featured in The Economist.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Political Economy | Princeton University | 2009-2013

Dissertation: Essays on the Political Economy of Service Delivery. Training in quantitative methods, econometrics, and experimental design.

Master of Public Policy | Princeton University | 2009-2011 | Concentration: Economics and Public Policy

Master in Economics | Universidad Nacional de La Plata, Argentina | 2005-2009

Bachelor of Economics | Universidad Nacional de La Plata, Argentina | 2000-2005 | Top 5 GPA Award

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

- Molina, E., Carter, E., Luna Bazaldua, D., Pushparatnam, A., & Singal, N. (2024). "Teaching for all? Measuring the quality of inclusive practices across eight countries." *Compare: A Journal of Comparative and International Education*, 54(4), 641-659.
- Carter, E., Molina, E., Pushparatnam, A., Rimm-Kaufman, S., Tsapali, M., & Wong, K.K.-Y. (2024). "Evidence-based teaching: effective teaching practices in primary school classrooms." *London Review of Education*, 22(1), 8.

- Molina, E., Fatima, S.F., Ho, A.D., Melo, C., Wilichowski, T.M., & Pushparatnam, A. (2020). "Measuring the quality of teaching practices in primary schools: Assessing the validity of the Teach observation tool in Punjab, Pakistan." *Teaching and Teacher Education*, 96, 103171.
- Buehren, N., Goldstein, M., Molina, E., & Vaillant, J. (2019). "The impact of strengthening agricultural extension services on women farmers: Evidence from Ethiopia." *Agricultural Economics*, 50(4), 407-419.
- Bold, T., Filmer, D., Martin, G., Molina, E., Stacy, B., Rockmore, C., Svensson, J., & Wane, W. (2017). "Enrollment Without Learning: Teacher Effort, Knowledge, and Skill in Primary Schools in Africa." *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 31(4), 185-204.
- Molina, E., Carella, L., Pacheco, A., Cruces, G., & Gasparini, L. (2017). "Community monitoring interventions to curb corruption and increase access and quality in service delivery: A systematic review." *Journal of Development Effectiveness*, 9(4), 462-499.
- Gasparini, L., Horenstein, M., Molina, E., & Olivieri, S. (2008). "Polarization in Latin America: Patterns and Links with Institutions and Conflict." *Oxford Development Studies*, 36(4), 461-484.

AI & Digital Innovation (185,000+ Downloads in ~2 Years)

- Molina, E., Cobo, C., Pineda, J., & Rovner, H. (2024). "AI Revolution in Education: What You Need to Know." *Digital Innovations in Education*. World Bank. [79,000+ downloads]
- Molina, E., & Medina, E. (2025). "AI Revolution in Higher Education: What You Need to Know." World Bank. [41,000+ downloads]
- Molina, E. (2025). "Screen Time in Early Childhood Education: Balancing the Digital Scales." World Bank. (December 2025) [17,000+ downloads]
- Molina, E., Lopez, C., Lizama, O., & Bambrick-Santoyo, P. (2025). "El Director LIBRE: El método de IA que libera horas de papeleo para liderar el aprendizaje." World Bank. (November 2025) [17,000+ downloads]
- Molina, E. et al. (2024). "Ceibal: Transforming Education in Uruguay through Technology." *Digital Innovations in Education*. World Bank. [9,000+ downloads]
- Burneo Teran, A., Dinarte-Diaz, L., Lopez, C., & Molina, E. (2026). "Can EdTech Close Learning Gaps?" Background paper for the World Development Report 2026. World Bank.

RECOGNITION & IMPACT

- **WBG Presidential Innovation Award (2025):** Winner of inaugural award for AI-driven education-to-employment platform, personally leading pitch to President Ajay Banga (1 of 7 winners selected Bank-wide)
- **10 World Bank Team Awards** (8 VPU Team Awards: 2015, 2017, 2022 [2x], 2024, 2025 [3x]; 2 Spot Awards: 2007, 2008)
- **Unprecedented Publication Impact: AI and digital publications achieved over 185,000 downloads in about two years—comparable to flagship World Development Report reach with minimal publicity.**
- **Global Thought Leadership:** Regular speaker at international conferences, ministerial forums, and universities; Featured in Microsoft CEO events, El Mercurio (Chile), Infobae (Peru), The Economist
- **Research Grants:** International Initiative for Impact Evaluation (3ie) Grant (\$74K); Princeton University Fellowship and research grants

TECHNICAL SKILLS & LANGUAGES

Languages: English (Fluent), Spanish (Native), Portuguese (Professional)

Digital & Technical: AI/ML applications in public sector, Digital solution design and scaling, Data-driven analytics (R, Stata, Python), Survey design and large-scale data collection, Impact evaluation and RCT design

Operational Expertise: IPF, PforR, GPE operations, DLI design, Results-based financing, Public expenditure analysis, Advisory services design